

8 Further Objections

Part 2: Evolution, Humor, and Revisionism

8.5 Do my arguments prove too much?

Assume that my arguments against moral anti-realism succeed. Would arguments of the same kind demonstrate realism about beauty? Perhaps. Some philosophers accept aesthetic realism in any case; moreover, 'beauty' may itself be an evaluative term—'beautiful' may imply 'good'—so this result would not be terribly surprising. Here is a more troubling question: Would such arguments also demonstrate realism about sexiness, funniness, and coolness (as in, 'The Matrix is a cool movie')? Realism about such properties is considerably less attractive than realism about value.³¹

To start with, consider non-cognitivism. Since sentences like 'I believe that Steven is funny' and 'If Steven is funny, then the audience will laugh' make sense and are sometimes appropriately asserted, it seems that non-cognitivism about funniness faces more or less the same problems as non-cognitivism about value. The linguistic arguments will probably work in exactly the same way, with about equal plausibility, in the case of any sentences that take the grammatical form of assertions, for any such sentences will probably be able to be embedded in larger sentences, just as evaluative claims can be. No intuitions specifically about the nature of funniness are required to make this argument.

The argument against 'nihilism' about funniness also seems analogous to the argument against value nihilism: the argument would consist in the display of some paradigmatically funny things, things that almost everyone would laugh at. Some searching might be required, since senses of humor vary, but let's assume we find such a paradigm.³² Suppose it is this joke:

An engineer, a scientist, a mathematician, and a philosopher are off in Ireland together, when they see a black sheep alone in a field. The engineer says, 'Hey, it looks like the sheep around here are black'. The scientist looks at him skeptically and replies, 'Well, at least some of them are'. Then the mathematician gives them another skeptical look and says, 'Well, at least one of them is'. Finally, the philosopher turns to them and says, 'Well, at least on one side'.

Pretend that upon hearing that, everyone laughs uproariously (including you). I invite you to agree that it was funny. How absurd it would be for the nihilist to claim, because of some dubious philosophical theory, that the joke wasn't funny!

Still, we might well feel humor nihilism to be less problematic than value nihilism. Giving up funniness assertions would involve a minor change to our belief systems. We won't have to stop laughing at things, since laughter is not a belief, nor is it caused or 'justified' by beliefs about funniness.

I would rather not deny that the above joke is funny. It seems funny to me. Perhaps our best bet is a subjectivist theory of funniness. Let's review the problems with value subjectivism from chapter 3 and see whether they apply to humor subjectivism:

i) The Problem of Horrible Attitudes: Imagine someone whose sense of humor diverges radically from ours (but not in a way that might be morally offensive, such as laughing at another's suffering). He goes outside and sees an ordinary stick, whereupon he breaks into hysterical laughter. The subjectivist says: 'For him, the stick is funny'. This does not seem obviously wrong, in the way that 'For Ted Bundy, murder is permissible' is obviously wrong.

On the other hand, some would likely describe this person as follows: 'He laughs at things that aren't funny'. Perhaps in this context, 'is funny' means approximately, 'would tend to make typical people laugh'. This implies that, if most of us are disposed to laugh at sticks, then sticks are funny. Again, this does not seem unacceptable in the way that 'If most of us approve of slavery, then slavery is good' is.

ii) The Problem of Disagreement: After hearing the same joke, one person says, 'That was funny', and another says, 'That was not funny'. The subjectivist says they are not disagreeing: one of them just means the joke was funny to him, while the other says it wasn't funny to him. This is not implausible. The sentence 'The joke is funny to me' makes sense, and the first person may well be willing to agree that that was what he meant. He is very unlikely to insist that the second person is wrong, nor to present arguments to show that the joke was funny, unless perhaps to say that most people would laugh at it. In contrast, the sentence, 'Abortion is wrong to me' does not make sense and cannot be substituted for 'Abortion is wrong'.

If someone says 'Abortion is not wrong', proliferers will say he is mistaken and will give arguments to show that abortion is wrong. Their arguments will not appeal to the claim that most people disapprove of abortion.

iii) The Problem of Arbitrariness: We argued that value subjectivism makes the attitudes or commands of the relevant person or group arbitrary. Such questions as 'Why should we obey arbitrary rules?' and 'How would someone's approving of $\$x\$$ for no reason make $\$x\$$ good?' then seem appropriate. Humor subjectivism, likewise, makes our laughter arbitrary—not in the sense that it cannot be causally explained, but in the sense that it cannot be justified. But this is not disturbing at all, in the way that arbitrariness in ethics would be. The question 'Why should we laugh at that joke?' does not naturally arise, and 'How would our being disposed to laugh at $\$x\$$ for no reason make $\$x\$$ funny?' seems unconvincing—we do not generally expect people to have reasons (that is, justifications) for laughter, in the sense that we might have reasons for our actions.

iv) The Problem of Fallibility: Fallibilism about humor likewise seems unconvincing. Suppose someone says, 'I find that joke funny, but I could be mistaken'. I find it hard to understand this—unless the speaker is referring to what most people would laugh at, or something of the sort. (Imagine someone who runs a comedy club trying to decide whom to hire for the evening's entertainment. He finds Sally funny, but later decides he was mistaken about her funniness when the audience merely groans.)

It seems, then, that humor subjectivism is far more defensible than moral subjectivism.

One further point. Many examples of 'obviously subjective' properties may have evaluative components, and this will stymie any attempt to give them purely subjectivist analyses. 'If baby-killing impressed a lot of people, then baby-killing would be cool' is false because baby-killing is bad, and 'cool' implies 'good' (whatever else it implies). Similarly, in some cases, a person may argue that something is 'not funny' on moral grounds—for instance, that it is inappropriate to laugh at a thing because doing so would offend others or express a bad attitude. Perhaps 'funny' implies 'not bad to laugh at'. 'Sexy' may similarly imply 'not bad (or abnormal) to feel sexual attraction towards'. If this is so, then of course these concepts will resist purely subjectivist treatments, but that would not pose a challenge to the arguments of this book.

8.6 Evolution and ethics

8.6.1 The evolutionary objection to realism

Sociobiologists (or 'evolutionary psychologists', in the current lingo) have offered explanations for moral behavior and moral beliefs, in terms of the theory of evolution. Since evolution generally leads us to expect selfishness, the main problem has been taken to be that of explaining why we often help others at some cost to ourselves. Proffered partial explanations include:

Kin selection: We help members of our own families, often at great expense to ourselves, because family members share many of the same genes. Helping one's family is thus an indirect way of increasing the reproduction of one's genes.

Reciprocal altruism: We help others because doing so tends to make them want to help us in return. Harming others or breaking agreements with them tends to make them angry and make them want to harm us.

Reputation effects: We behave nicely because doing so improves our general reputation in our community, causing others to regard us as good trading partners, and so on. One who breaks agreements or attacks people is likely to be widely shunned.

Sociobiologists do not say that we go through the above kinds of reasoning before deciding what to do, but rather that these arguments explain why our feelings of wanting to be nice to each other have reproductive value.

Some say that evolutionary theory's ability to explain our moral beliefs undermines moral realism, particularly ethical intuitionism. There are three arguments for this.³⁴

First: Since sociobiology provides adequate explanations for our moral beliefs, and these explanations do not appeal to objective values, there is no need to posit objective values. They do not help us explain anything, and our overall theory is simpler without them. Nor need we posit a special cognitive faculty of moral intuition, when we could explain moral beliefs by appeal to emotions, which in turn are explained evolutionarily.

Second: Even if there are objective values, the evolutionary explanation of our moral beliefs gives us no reason to expect that our intuitions would tend to correspond to the moral truth. This stands in contrast to other cognitive faculties. An organism with poor vision will fare worse in terms of survival and reproduction than an organism with accurate vision. A person who mistakes tigers for peach trees will have diminished survival prospects. But we have no account of how reproductive fitness would be enhanced by correct moral beliefs.

Third: Not only do we lack an account of why we should tend to have correct moral beliefs, but the sociobiological account of moral beliefs provides positive grounds for expecting our moral beliefs not to be reliable, assuming there is an objective moral truth. This is because evolution would tend to give us strong biases in favor of ourselves, our kin, and members of our own social group. Evolution would mold our moral attitudes towards its own purposes, to ensure behavior that increases reproductive fitness, regardless of what is actually morally right.

The first argument suggests that there are no objective values. The latter two suggest that, even if there are, we have no way of knowing about them.

8.6.2 The realist's burden

It is important to remember that intuitionists do not say that we have a 'special moral sense', that is, a separate faculty dedicated solely to cognizing moral truths. Intuition is a function of reason. Moral intuition differs from mathematical intuition in the way that perceptions of cars differ from perceptions of trees—that is, merely in having different objects. There is thus no special explanation required for how 'the faculty of moral intuition' evolved.

Consider an analogous case: why do we have the ability to see stars? After all, our evolutionary ancestors presumably would have done just as well if they only saw things on Earth. Of course, this is a silly question. We can see the stars because we have vision, which is useful for seeing things on Earth, and once you have vision, you wind up seeing whatever is there sending light in your direction, whether it is a useful thing to see or not. Likewise, once you have intelligence, you wind up apprehending the sorts of things that can be known by reason, whether they are useful to know or not. Thus, humans are capable of learning to play chess at an incredibly sophisticated level, despite that the environment of *Australopithecus* contained no chess boards. If some evaluative truths can be known through reason, we would likely know them whether they were useful to know or not.[35]

Note that moral theory does not need to be positively validated by the theory of evolution, any more than any other branch of knowledge does. In order to know that $2 + 2 = 4$, we do not have to first consult the sociobiologists and see whether evolution predicts that humans would have correct mathematical beliefs.[36] In order to know that there is a computer before me, I do not have to first see whether evolution predicts that humans would have correct physical-object beliefs. This is fortunate, since if this were a requirement, we could gain no knowledge of the physical world before we knew the theory of evolution, in which case we would have no way of verifying that theory to begin with. We have seen that some moral beliefs can reasonably be taken as foundational, just as some mathematical and perceptual beliefs can. The initial justification for beliefs about moral facts does not derive from their fitting into a sociobiological explanation, nor from the ability of moral facts to explain natural facts.

The anti-realist thus should not argue against realism on the ground that sociobiology fails to predict that we would have moral knowledge. That argument would be no more plausible than the argument that we should reject arithmetic because sociobiology fails to predict that we would have knowledge of it. But the anti-realist may argue that sociobiology predicts that we would not have moral knowledge. Here, the assumption would not be that morality needs outside validation, but only that it can be undermined by its tension with other justified beliefs. Therefore, in my following replies, I need only argue that the theory of evolution does not determinately predict absence of moral knowledge.

8.6.3 How good are evolutionary accounts of ethics?

Evolutionary explanations of ethics are unimpressive—certainly not impressive enough that their existence justifies making a radical revision of our belief system and rejecting all moral beliefs.

What would be an 'impressive' set of explanations? First, it would be one that promised specific explanations for all the major ethical intuitions, including the ones that are the most plausible examples of rational principles. It should explain intuitions about such things as the supervenience of value, universalizability, the asymmetry and transitivity of 'better than', rights, and the Categorical Imperative. It should promise us explanations for the details of our intuitions about particular situations, such as the seemingly divergent intuitions in the trolley car problem and the organ-harvesting

example.³⁷ With few exceptions, evolutionary explanations of ethics purport to explain moral behavior only in the vaguest outlines, taking morality to consist of little more specific than the imperative, 'Cooperate'. The only relatively specific moral beliefs that sociobiologists have so far explained are the ones that initially seem the most tailor-made for evolutionary explanation and the worst candidates for rational moral beliefs—for example, moral beliefs about incest, special obligations to family, and reproductive practices.³⁸

Second, it would be a set of explanations that implied unique, or at least fairly specific predictions about the content of morality. That is, it should be evident that the explanatory framework being used could not accommodate a vast range of different moral beliefs and behaviors, but requires moral beliefs to take fairly specific forms—so that the hypothesis that moral beliefs are evolved adaptations would have been falsified if we had had very different moral intuitions from those we actually have. For instance, we would like an explanatory framework that could explain why the Golden Rule would be accepted but could not accommodate widespread acceptance of egoism (given that egoism is contrary to our moral intuitions).

Why impose this requirement? Michael Ruse is arguing that the availability of evolutionary explanations of ethics is compelling evidence against moral realism. But if evolutionary explanations of ethics would most likely have been available whether or not realism was true—say, because one can think of an evolutionary explanation for virtually anything—then the fact that they are available is not significant evidence against realism.

Many have complained that sociobiology is 'unfalsifiable'.³⁹ My claim is weaker: I am not criticizing sociobiology in general, nor am I claiming that the idea of an evolutionary explanation for ethical beliefs could not be falsified by any evidence. My claim is that there is such a wide range of conceivable ethical beliefs that could be given an evolutionary explanation, that the fact that our actual ethical beliefs are susceptible to one (if they are) does not tell us much. If we had had a widespread intuition that ethical egoism was true (the right action is always the action that best serves one's own interests), wouldn't sociobiologists have laid claim to a rather straightforward explanation for this? But our actual moral intuitions (on this one dimension of egoism vs. altruism) are nearly the opposite. If sociobiologists can explain this too, then the range of moral beliefs they could in principle accommodate is very wide. To give a more extreme example of the flexibility of the paradigm, some sociobiologists have even claimed homosexuality to be an adaptation.⁴⁰ If even homosexuality can be fit into the sociobiological paradigm, it is unsurprising that some moral beliefs can be.

8.6.4 An evolutionary account of moral perception

On my account, the correct explanation for why we have ethical intuition will refer to whatever is the explanation for why we have reason and intelligence in general. However, I now want to set that point aside and suggest that there is an additional evolutionary explanation available for why people should have correct ethical beliefs. This explanation requires four assumptions:

- a) A moral system fairly takes account of everyone's interests. This is not all there is to morality, but it is one (perhaps analytically) necessary aspect of morality. A system of rules that ignored interests, or that took account of some interests while arbitrarily excluding others, would not be a moral system. There are different possible ways of fairly taking account of interests, of course—for instance, consequentialist ways and rights-based ways. I won't try to analyze 'fair' here, but it is to be understood as a contrast to 'biased'.
- b) Peaceful cooperation provides benefits to all that generally outweigh any benefits that could be gained by exploitation of others. Conflict with others causes harms that generally outweigh any benefits that might be non-cooperatively extracted. Suppose you have \$100 that I want. I decide to go to your house and take it, whereupon a fight ensues. Since I am stronger, I win the fight and get the \$100. However, I suffer a broken arm in the process, a harm much worse than the loss of \$100. You are even worse off than I am (with two broken arms, say), but this is irrelevant; my goal was to benefit myself, not to hurt you, so I have failed.
- c) Peaceful cooperation requires an agreed-upon set of rules. If I am operating under rules that assign ownership of that \$100 to me, while you are operating under rules that assign ownership of the same \$100 to you, then a conflict is likely to ensue. If the two of us are trying to cooperate in some endeavor, but we have very different understandings of what each of us is required to do, then our cooperation is likely to break down.
- d) Agreement on a set of social rules is unlikely unless those rules fairly take into account everyone's interests. If I am operating under rules that are biased in my favor, then I am unlikely to find anyone who agrees with them. To achieve peaceful cooperation with others, I need to accept rules that fairly take into account both my and their interests.

This doesn't yet get us to the correct set of moral rules. My suggestion, however, is that people with a capacity for moral intuition would enjoy the advantage of agreeing with each other on a set of rules that permits social cooperation, since it fairly takes account of everyone's interests. This is not the only way that such coordination might be achieved, but it is one way. People lacking accurate moral intuition might see no reason to accept a set of social rules, or might be inclined to accept a set of rules skewed in their own favor. Even if they accepted sets of rules that fairly took account of everyone's interests, it is likely that they would still not agree, since there are many possible such sets of rules. Since there is only one truth, those with accurate moral perception avoid this problem.⁴¹

My claims for this explanation are modest. Perhaps it is roughly correct; perhaps not. In any case, it shows that it is possible for accurate moral perception to have survival value.

I do not deny that sociobiology can teach us something about ethics. As noted, evolution may have endowed us with biases that affect our moral judgments. Sociobiology can help us identify these biases, and so correct for them, thereby improving our moral cognition.

8.7 Is intuitionism too revisionary?

Given that current moral beliefs and practices can be expected to correspond strongly with our moral intuitions, it is natural to assume that intuitionism leads to very conservative ethical views. But this need not be so. Consider the analogous case of our knowledge of the external world. Science tells us that the sun is 1.3 million times larger than the Earth, that invisible force fields fill all of space, and that ordinary material objects are composed of tiny, colorless particles in rapid motion, with great spaces between them. These conclusions are surprising and quite far from the way things appear to casual observation. Yet scientists do not possess some new cognitive faculty that common folk are deprived of; science is based, solely or primarily, on observation.

Similarly, moral reasoning might lead to surprising and revisionary conclusions, despite that this reasoning must ultimately be based on intuition. An intuitionist will accept intuitions as a source of *prima facie* justification, but he should not accept intuitions *uncritically*, any more than a scientist accepts apparent observations uncritically. As we saw in chapter 6, there are many ways our intuitions and beliefs can go wrong, and the wise intuitionist will be on guard against these sources of error.

From the intuitionist perspective, there is good reason to believe that a revisionary moral theory is in fact called for. Many commonly held moral beliefs look more like products of self-interest, cultural indoctrination, or the imperatives of natural selection than like products of careful, rational reflection.⁴² For example, the widespread belief that polygamy is wrong apparently derives from our particular culture.⁴³ Most cultures have practiced polygamy without considering it wrong at all, and few who hold the belief that polygamy is wrong can offer any plausible reasons for that judgment; nor is the wrongness of polygamy the sort of thing we would expect to simply be a fundamental evaluative truth, incapable of further explanation. Likewise, few are prepared to give any rational account of the alleged wrongness of incest; most of us, it seems, just *feel* that it is wrong.⁴⁴ Some have speculated that this has an evolutionary explanation, relating to the increased risk of birth defects resulting from incest.⁴⁵ And the widespread belief that, while killing human beings for food is one of the most heinous wrongs imaginable, killing members of any other species for food is not even slightly wrong, seems more easily explained by self-interest, culture, and/or natural selection than by rational insight. Again, the belief hardly seems like an axiomatic evaluative truth, yet most who hold it are unable to advance any credible reasons for it.⁴⁶ Anti-realists take all this as evidence against moral realism;⁴⁷ intuitionists, however, will simply take it as reason to reject the particular moral beliefs in question.

It would take us too far afield to discuss the merits of these and other common moral beliefs here. But suppose it turns out that reflection by the most careful and thorough of intuitionists leads them to deny a great many, perhaps the majority of commonly held moral beliefs. We might then worry that intuitionism is **too revisionary*. The rough idea I have in mind here is this: The meanings of (all or most of) the words in our language, including 'wrong' and 'permissible', are determined by how they are typically used by those who speak the language. For this reason, it cannot be the case that a word is normally misused; a sufficiently common 'misuse' of a term simply generates a new meaning for the term. By the same token, a person who uses a word radically differently (in the sense of applying it to a very different class of things) from how it is ordinarily used may be accused of simply misunderstanding the word. Thus, imagine someone who denies that such animals as German shepherds, poodles, and Scotch terriers are dogs; instead, he says, they are chairs. This person would rightly be accused, on these grounds alone, of misunderstanding the word 'chair'. This is not to deny that people who understand the term 'chair' can sometimes mistake non-chair items for chairs. But a person cannot understand the English

word 'chair' and yet consistently take it to apply to a very different kind of object from that to which most English speakers apply it. One might say: it cannot turn out that German shepherds are chairs, because that is just not what we mean by 'chair'.

Similarly, I imagine an anti-realist arguing as follows:

1. If intuitionism is true, then wrongness exists and is an objective property that we are aware of by rational intuition. (Premise.)
2. There is no objective property that we are aware of by rational intuition, that most of the things people typically call 'wrong' have in common. (Premise.)
3. Therefore, if intuitionism is true, then wrongness exists, but most of the things people typically call 'wrong' do not have it. (From 1, 2.)
4. It cannot be the case that wrongness exists but that most of the things people typically call 'wrong' do not have it. (Premise.)
5. Therefore, intuitionism is false. (From 3, 4.)

Premise (1) simply restates (part of) the theory of ethical intuitionism. Premise (2) is supported by the fact that people—on the basis of emotions and other non-rational causes—commonly judge actions to be 'wrong' that do not appear to have any relevant objective feature in common. Premise (4) is supported by the general conception of language just discussed, according to which the meaning of a word is normally determined by its use.⁴⁸

How should an intuitionist respond? The first problem is that the argument for premise (4) elides an important distinction between two senses in which a word might be 'misused'. In the first and more proper sense, a word is misused when it is used to mean something that it does not mean according to the conventions of the language. For example, in the sentence, 'In saying that he would not raise taxes on the middle class, the President inferred that he might raise taxes on other groups', the word 'inferred' is incorrectly used to mean 'implied'. In the second sense, a word might be said to be 'misused' when, roughly, it is applied to something that does not have the property the word refers to. For example, in the sentence, 'Elizabeth Proctor is a witch', the word 'witch' is incorrectly applied to Proctor, who is not in fact a witch. It is not, however, misused in the first sense—it is not used to mean something that the word does not normally mean. Now, it is true, for the reason stated above (that usage determines words' meanings), that a word cannot be generally misused in the first sense. But as the example of the word 'witch' shows, a word can be generally misused in the second sense; indeed, the word 'witch' has been misused in this sense every time it has been applied to anyone—for as I assume, there are no witches. Similarly, then, it is conceivable that the word 'wrong' is commonly 'misused' in the sense of being applied to things that do not have the property of wrongness—though not, of course, in the sense of being used to mean something that it does not normally mean. Thus, premise (4) seems to be false; at any rate, it is not supported by the mere fact that word meanings are generally determined by usage.

Still, I do not think that the charge that intuitionism is too revisionary is entirely without plausibility. While the objection we have been discussing fails to show that it is conceptually incoherent to attribute massive moral error to people, it may nevertheless be true that the meaning of 'wrong' in English is such as to preclude the possibility of the kind of error I have hypothesized. Perhaps most people's understanding of the word is so closely tied to such supposed paradigms of wrongness as incest, polygamy, and cleaning the toilet with the national flag⁴⁹ that it is analytically true that, if wrongness exists at all, then those actions have it. Perhaps, at the same time, most people's understanding of 'wrong' is sufficiently loosely tied to the notion of reasons for action that the fact (if this is a fact) that there exist sufficient all-things-considered reasons for not eating non-human animals does not suffice to establish that such eating is wrong. I say 'perhaps' because, while I do not believe these things are the case, I am not sure that they aren't. And so I want to address the question of how an intuitionist should react if these things are the case and if, at the same time, reflection reveals no relevant objective property that incest, polygamy, and cleaning the toilet with the flag have in common.

Briefly, I think an intuitionist could, without rendering his position uninteresting, accept the charge of using some words, such as 'morally right' and 'morally wrong', in non-standard senses. I intend my use of the word 'wrong' to refer, roughly speaking, to the property about which (most of) the following are true: it is objective; it is not a physical property; only intentional actions can have it; murder, theft, the breaking of promises, and other actions that harm others or violate others' rights typically have it; when an action has it, there are sufficient all-things-considered reasons against performing

that action; guilt and remorse are typical and appropriate reactions to the awareness that an action of one's own had it; blame is a typical and appropriate response to the awareness that an action of someone else's had it; an action has it only if the agent could have refrained from performing that action; an action cannot have it if the action is permissible, praiseworthy, or obligatory. When I say that polygamy is not wrong, I mean that polygamy has no feature of which all or most of those things are true.

The most important of the conditions is that wrong actions are actions that there are sufficient, objective reasons not to perform. The core of my intuitionism is the claim that we can sometimes see, intuitively, objective reasons for action, reasons that do not depend on any contingent desires or other psychological responses of ours. If it turns out, as might be the case, that a sufficiently large number of English speakers do not use the word 'wrong' even roughly this way—perhaps because they do not understand 'x is wrong' to imply that there are sufficient reasons not to do x, or because they understand merely subjective reasons as counting towards an action's wrongness—then I would perhaps agree to a change of terminology. Perhaps, instead of 'ethical intuitionism', I should call the theory I have been defending 'evaluative intuitionism' or 'intuitionism about practical reasons'.